

Vertigo!!!

Newsletter of the New Zealand Alpine Club, Wellington Section

NO. 675 January 2005 PO BOX 1 6 2 8 W E L L I N G T O N

Club nights are at Turnbull House, on the first unimpeded Monday of every month. New and prospective members are welcome. Meet for dinner at the Backbencher public bar at 6.30 and on to Turnbull House at 7.30 pm for a catch up. Meetings and talks start at 8.00 pm with club business and tea and coffee afterwards.



S/Night: Monday 7 February 2005 **ANNUAL BARBECUE AT FERGS**

This is the first section night for 2005 and is the traditional begin-the-year-with-a-bang(er) BBQ at Fergs Rock Wall on the waterfront.

Not only will there be free sausages and food, but there will be free climbing as well!

The BBQ and climbing start at 6 pm – see you there.

March Section Night – Monday March 7 2005

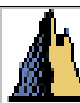
This will be one of the year's 2 short talks night (the other in September).

Short talks are limited to 15 mins, so dig out your summer slides or jpg's (remember the club now has a digital projector) and come along to inspire other club members with your latest exploits.

Contact Caroline Duggan (cd@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz) with details.



Head of Jollie. L to R Abbess, Abbot, Jollie Peak, Jollie saddle(obsured), Don French



Section trips news

Please send all your fantastic trip reports to newsletter@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz, so everyone can enjoy your stories.

Plan I or 9th Time Lucky?

During the last week in November we made several attempts to climb Mt Aspiring. A number of hut days were experienced with the passing of 3 storm events, almost a metre of fresh snow, and winds gusting over 130 km/h. After 4 days in Colin Todd Hut we got a limited weather window. From a 3.45am start up the Therma Glacier route conditions were calm and mostly clear. But upon acquiring the NW ridge (opposite The Ramp) the weather started to deteriorate. We pushed on acquiring the summit at 9.31am in 100km/h winds, cold conditions (-4C), and low visibility (50-100m). Upon leaving the area (via the Bonar/Quarterdeck) we got a blue sky day (what else!) although it was still extremely windy throughout. For further details see: www.geocities.com/kevin_patterson1/tripreports/aspiring/aspiringtripreport.html.

Kevin Patterson/Tom Zink

A France contribution....

Jay Piggott, Paul Prince, Mark Dolan and Stephen France climbed the North-west face of Mt Ionia during the Christmas / New Year break. We took a local farmers jet boat 50km up the Arawhata to near 10 hour gorge on the 27th, then ascended through the bush to a campsite at 1200m. The summit was gained the following morning in deteriorating weather but with excellent snow conditions. A storm set in the afternoon and the next 18 hours were spent tent bound in a storm. After a ripped tent on the morning of the 29th and forecast continued unpleasant weather, plans to continue on to Arawhata Saddle and the Matukituki valley were shelved and we returned to the Arawhata after arranging a jetboat pick-up later that afternoon. The Arawhata was in full flood, over 1km wide in places, and an exciting ride down river to the road ensued, dodging floating trees. A good time was had by all.

Stephen France

And a French contribution....

Got in a Jollie quick ascent of Nuns Veil on one of the few fine days over the Christmas New Year period. Approached it from the Jollie river (on Breamar). The Jollie is easy going with a full day's travel to its head. Two huts of note, Green Point (Musters Hut, sleeps 6, reasonable condition, Breamar) and Littles (Poor, but water tight, sleeps 2). Placed high camp in head of Pinnacle stream (H36 891198) on a nice flat spot just on the snow line. Next day the ascent up the couloir to join the Nuns Veil Glacier and to the summit went very quickly with the summit being achieved in only 3 hours from the camp. That afternoon the party retreated down the Jollie under a greying sky. According to the Hut books, the last party that recorded climbing intentions in the Jollie was in 1976. But I'm sure that it has had the odd visit since then.

Don French (with Rowan Payne and Kurt Mullis of Wellington)

The Importance of Not Being Ernest!

In December Colin Monteath (mentor), John Nankervis, and "Theo from Montana" tried to repeat Shackleton's crossing of South Georgia from King Haakon Bay to Stromness. They were hit by a blizzard and retreated in the whiteout to the northern coast at Possession Bay where, menaced by fur seals, they were picked up by zodiac from a passing trip (theirs). Later, on a lovely day with a bigger group, they walked the final section of Ernie's route from Fortuna Bay to the abandoned whaling station at Stromness.

Ski Touring - Nelson Lakes

In September Dave Ellis, Mark Ellis and Ben Ellis (but not necessarily in that order) and John Nankervis skied along the Robert Ridge to Angelus Hut and back. They climbed Angelus and skied down from near the top. Two weeks later the powder had gone and spring had arrived. Clinton Wadsworth, Wilf Dickerson and John Nankervis carried skis from the Matakita up onto the Mole Tops and camped in the first big basin. They toured the basins between there and Mount Watson in perfect weather. The south facing slopes were a tad slick as Nank found to his anguish and cost.

Gold

On their annual New Year trip John Cocks, John Nankervis, Paul Dennis and Dave Bamford were driven east from Fiordland by the cold nasties. They retreated to the warmth of Skippers Creek, camped and hutted in the beautiful Aurum basin, scrambled up Mount Aurum and then descended by the other branch of Skippers Creekall so redolent of gold mining days.

John Nankervis

And the weather does its thing....

We (myself, Peter Rowe, Malcolm McGeachie, and Duncan Rait) had hoped to do a bit of alpine rock climbing at Mt Cook over the Christmas break. However, un-settled weather meant we didn't even venture into the Park. Instead, Malcolm, Pete, and myself spent a couple of days cragging on the Port Hills and at Hanging Rock on December 28th and 29th waiting for the weather to sort itself out. We reached Unwin Hut on the night of the 29th in torrential rain where we met up with Duncan. We then spent the 30th waiting to be flown into Tasman Saddle, but conditions were never suitable. We decided to head for the South Temple Valley instead and left that night.

We were greeted by more torrential rain at Twizel and all the way on the drive in next to Lake Ohau. Luckily there is a nice shelter at the South Temple Road end, handy for cooking and sleeping under. The sandflies are brutal though, which meant we all got up quite early. The weather was clearing however and we slogged up to Gunsight Pass via the North Temple and into the top of the South Temple with packs full of rock gear, as well as ice tools (for a possible climb on Mt Huxley). We set up camp on some lovely tussock benches at the 1500m contour. We were all a bit tired from the walk in though, so decided to rest that afternoon. Probably a good idea, as the rain came in again and lasted all night.

About 10am on the 1st it decided to clear so we headed off for a climb that afternoon. Duncan and I climbed Weta Prowl (3+ and about 300m) on the west face of Steeple Peak, which consisted of generally easy scrambling on slabs and some exposed ridge traverses to the summit. The rock was fairly compact, although there were a few close calls from rock loosened by stuck abseil ropes on the decent. Malcolm and Pete climbed another route onto the minor summit of Steeple Peak.

The weather cleared up nicely that night so we headed off early on the morning of the 2nd. Duncan and I climbed the Southwest Buttress (Butterfly Buttress 4, and about 500m) of Bruce Peak, which was excellent climbing on very firm rock (except for a very loose and blocky section just above the snow). We also saw another party trying an unclimbed line, but they bailed off about 1/3 of the way up and we didn't see them again. We had excellent views on the summit from Mt Hooker up to Cook, but the divide was well covered in cloud on the western side. Pete and Malcolm climbed Weta Prowl on Steeple Peak.

Snow conditions were not too good, with lots of sloughs on any slopes in the sun so we decided not to try Mt Huxley and headed back out to the road end, via the South Temple Valley (an easy and very scenic route). The forecast for the mountains still didn't look too good so we spent a couple of days cragging in Wanaka, a day in the rain on the West Coast, and even managed to sneak in 2 fine days at Paynes, in between more torrential rain.

Eric Duggan

In other news....

Pamela Doake and Mike Peat headed south with the masses over the holidays. Mike says in between the espressos and sun baking, the pair managed a few days' tramping in Nelson Lakes, followed by a crossing of Ball Pass.

Kris Persson, Vanessa Johnson and Rachael Schmidt had an epic attempt on Mt Aspiring in winter-like conditions via the Therma in the first week of December. Kris made the summit in appalling conditions, before the trio spent a night in a snowcave on the Bonar during a storm.

Garth and Angie London, Rachael Schmidt and Nicky McIndoe (ex-Wgtn section member now in the UK), spent a few weeks down south over Xmas/New Year avoiding the rain and getting in some good tramping including the Five Passes in Aspiring National Park. There was still a fair bit of snow on Fohn Saddle and Fiery Col, and the group discovered the joys of Grade 14 rock manoeuvres on snowgrass!

Pete's Post (did you all see him on TV talking to Sir Ed?!)

It only hurts when I laugh. Not true, actually it hurts all the time. Yesterday we had another SAR training day, which involved jumping into big crevasses and relying on my two rope-partners to hold the fall. (We had a safety belay as well). Then I had to prussik out while the others built an anchor. Maybe I'm getting old, or perhaps it was the big overhanging lip plus the fact we didn't have crampons and ice axe with us (or maybe it's because...Ed). But my arms are very sore today.

The next exercise was to put someone in a rescue litter and drag them across the snow to a point where we could lower them down through the icefall. Of course we picked the fattest

person as our victim (and NO, it wasn't me). The snow was deep and soft, with us two kiwis pulling the litter like a sled. Ten Americans followed along to control the direction and to yell at each other. It was very physical due to the snow conditions and was a good workout for my legs. They are sore today as well.

Christmas and New Year were celebrated appropriately with a dinner and a party. We have a local FM radio station on the base, and a survey was taken to see if people wanted Christmas songs played. The result was 35 against and only two people for this proposal.

A few minutes ago I saw a penguin grovelling along the ice in front of the base. Since we are about 20km away from the nearest penguin colony and since he should have been heading the other way to get to sea, I assumed he must be lost. I've offered to teach him some navigation, but it will obviously need to be GPS-based. The Magnetic South Pole is actually north of us and about 1600 km away (magnetic variation was 155 degrees 24.87 minutes when I last measured it). Because we are quite close to the magnetic pole and the earth's magnetic field is always changing in position and intensity, navigation by compass is a waste of time here. The rocks are volcanic and highly magnetic, and we are only 30km away from Mt Erebus - an active lava-crater volcano. As you move around with your compass you can detect big local anomalies in the magnetic direction. It's a great excuse if you ever get lost (Wonder if that excuse would work in the Orongorongo's Merewyn).

We had some students here from Chch university, doing a Graduate Certificate in Antarctic Studies. They camped out in Windless Bight for 2 weeks, and we were involved in supporting their work. One of them was Linda Clarke, who did the AIC with us in 2004. It was good to catch up with her and see what she had learnt. She seemed very comfortable in this environment. One day they were out on a field trip, when their Hagglunds vehicle hit soft snow and the rear cab rolled over. No-one was hurt, but I was in the first vehicle to arrive at the scene. We put them into our vehicle and someone else ferried them back to their camp while I stayed to assist with winching the Hagglunds upright again.

Things have been quiet here since the GCAS students left shortly after Christmas. The weather has been warm with light winds but low cloud. Several incoming flights have been cancelled due to poor visibility or mechanical problems. We are now well behind with the incoming scientist schedule, and also with the mail/newspaper/fresh vegetables schedules. All the new toys I've been buying are stuck in Christchurch, but as long as they arrive before the last flight at the end of February it will be okay. We are now focussed on the jobs that need to be done before the end of the season, which is approaching very quickly.

That's all to report this month. Tune in for next month's thrilling installment.

Pete de Joux from Antarctica



39 Mercer Street, PO Box 1560, Wellington, New Zealand
Ph/Fax (04) 4735353 email mainly.tramping@paradise.net.nz



RIP Niklas

Mike Peat: "It's with sadness that I have to report that my friend Niklas Werner died in a fall on Mt Aspiring on the 11th of January. Niklas along with Markus Bai had summited earlier in the day, they were descending the ramp unroped in the late afternoon when Niklas slipped and fell about 100m to the Glacier.

Niklas was in NZ completing his doctoral studies in music at Waikato University, and was making every week count in the hills also. A visit to his website www.niklaswerner.de will reveal an extensive photo essay of his time here with numerous biking, tramping, rock climbing, skiing and mountaineering trips catalogued.

Niklas's funeral will be held in Berlin in early February and a memorial service will be held in Hamilton shortly thereafter."



Simon Yates

Simon Yates, made famous by the best selling book and BAFTA winning docu-drama movie 'Touching the Void', is to undertake a lecture tour in New Zealand in February 2005. The tour is organised and hosted by the New Zealand Alpine Club and will feature public lectures in Auckland, Wellington, Nelson, Christchurch, Dunedin and Wanaka/Queenstown.

In a career spanning twenty years Simon Yates' climbing and travelling has taken him from Alaska in the west to Australia in the east, from the Canadian Arctic in the north to the tip of South America. During this time he has been fortunate enough to climb with some of Britain's leading contemporary mountaineers. He first came to prominence as a mountaineer in 1985 after the first ascent of the West Face of Siula Grande in the Peruvian Andes and the ensuing epic descent described in Simpson's book 'Touching the Void' and the 2003 BAFTA winning docu-drama of the same name.

While providing a lengthy insight into the drama from his own unique perspective, Simon will also take a humorous and philosophical look at some of the more notable experiences over his years as a mountaineer, accompanied by a stunning selection of slides collected during his travels. In a climbing career spanning two decades, he has undertaken ascents in some of the worlds most remote regions.

WHEN: 7:30pm Sun 13 Feb 2005

WHERE: The Paramount Theatre

TICKETS: \$15.00 from Bivouac / Mainly Tramping



SUMMER ROCK 2005

The Wellington Section will again be running its hugely popular Summer Rock course. This is a highly worthwhile course consisting of 3 weekends on real rock and a few evening sessions down at Fergs. Details to come, but in the meantime to register an interest or find out more, you can contact Scott or Mike on 380 0913 or email mike_goesaclimbn@hotmail.com

ROCK HOP 2005

A fun day out for all!

Baring Head Rock Hop

29 January 2005

11am start

- \$10 entry fee
- Recreation, expert, youth and masters categories
- BBQ and prize giving at the Rimutaka Forest Park afterwards
- Sunday 30th January postponement day

Check out www.powerband.org.nz or your local climbing shop/ gym for further information.

NZAC Journals

The club has had a set of NZAC journals donated by Dawn Everson to be sold and the proceeds to be donated to the Home of Mountaineering fund. The collection consists of every journal since 1935 to 2003 except for 1999. They are being sold by tender and you can tender for individual journals or the whole set. You should send your tender to Keith Moffat e-mail moffat.k@xtra.co.nz or post to 172 Gladstone Rd Dunedin. Tenders close on 28th February 2005. Delivery to be paid by the purchaser.

For Sale

For sale: Adjustable 12 point crampons with key in Charlet Moset crampon bag. Good condition. \$140. Contact Chris on 021 307 353.

Makalu La Sportiva boots, mens size 41 European. Hardly worn though have been snow sealed, in excellent condition.

\$200neg, phone Erin 021 339382 or email erinpentie@yahoo.com

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Quiz Number 15 – Special Xmas Quiz

During World War Two, two New Zealand soldiers serving in Europe made a pledge to climb Mt Blanc after the war. One of the soldiers was killed before the end of the war, but the surviving soldier kept his promise and climbed the mountain before he returned to New Zealand. The story of his ascent is recorded in a poem he wrote about the climb. Extracts from the poem, "The Long Way Back", are given below.

Who was the climber-poet?

Email your answers to NR@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz by no later than 28 February 2005. Be sure to put Quiz Number 15 in the email's subject line (or else your email is highly likely to be destroyed as spam). The winning entry will be drawn at the section night meeting on Monday, 7 March 2005, and the winner will receive half-a-dozen bottles of Monteith's black beer.

The Long Way Back

Six hours up the icefall on the south face
We encounter a line of fresh tracks
That draws us across the mountain's shoulder
Into a high-level hut of unlined metal
To surprise a party of Swiss, laughing and talking
Over their experiences on the tourist route
From Chamonix ...

They look disbelievingly at our improvised gear-
Wehrmacht rucksacks, Alpini boots, Kaiapoi woollen
Jerseys, caps comforter, and old army socks for gloves.

...

Then we buckle on crampons, adjust the rope
And start up the summit ridge;
The Italian leads and I'm up close,
Axe ready, rope tightly in hand.
Every 50 metres or so we lean over our axes
And drag at the air like old men on difficult stairs.
The wind is now so sharp there's no stopping
For more than freezing seconds;
Soon it's my turn to chip each step
Precisely lest a slip sends us sliding

...

In corroboration of last winter's pact
Made when we were fugitives
In the landscape of our choosing:
'When it's over we'll celebrate-
We'll climb the highest point in the Alps'

...

Each step towards the summit
I keep thinking about my friend
And all the mountains we might have climbed
Together ...

But for a moment longer I wait,

Arm in arm against the wind,
Hesitating on the extreme arc of memory,
Staring down into Italy
While tears freeze in my eyes
For ever.



And here are the club trips...

Wellington Section Trips

Trips are a key part of the section, so if anyone has an idea about a trip, no matter how vague, come and chat to Michele Domaneschi or Rachel Depree (trips@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz).

Trips can be of any length, any level of difficulty, and any size. Simply email us, or approach us at the monthly meeting, and we can help you get going.

See you in the hills! WE NEED MORE TRIPS! COME ON GUYS

Trips for the Calendar for the rest of 2005...

Check out the proposed and planned new list for 2005. We need trip organisers to put their hands up for what are bound to be outstanding adventures. There's something for everyone in here with a mix of snow, rock and even a spot of ski touring.

Proposed...

Mangatepopo	<i>March 2005</i>
<i>Trip type:</i> Rock	<i>Level:</i> Intermediate – Advanced
<i>Organiser:</i> Merewyn Ellis (merewyn@dialogue.co.nz)	
Rolleston via Rome Ridge, Arthur's Pass.. Take a day and make it a 4 day weekend.	

Taranaki or Maungaotaki	<i>ANZAC Weekend (April) 2005</i>
<i>Trip type:</i> Rock	<i>Level:</i> Intermediate – Advanced
<i>Organiser:</i> Michele Domaneschi (md@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz)	
Location dependent on weather.	

Mt Rolleston	<i>Queens Birthday Weekend</i>
<i>Trip type:</i> Alpine	<i>Level:</i> Intermediate – Advanced
<i>Organiser:</i> Merewyn Ellis (merewyn@dialogue.co.nz)	
Rolleston via Rome Ridge, Arthur's Pass.. Take a day and make it a 4 day weekend.	



MOVED HOUSE?

Please notify the Club's National Administrator of your change of address as the labels for all newsletters and club publications are generated at the HQ office.

Margaret McMahon

email office@alpineclub.org.nz

NZAC

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CHRISTCHURCH

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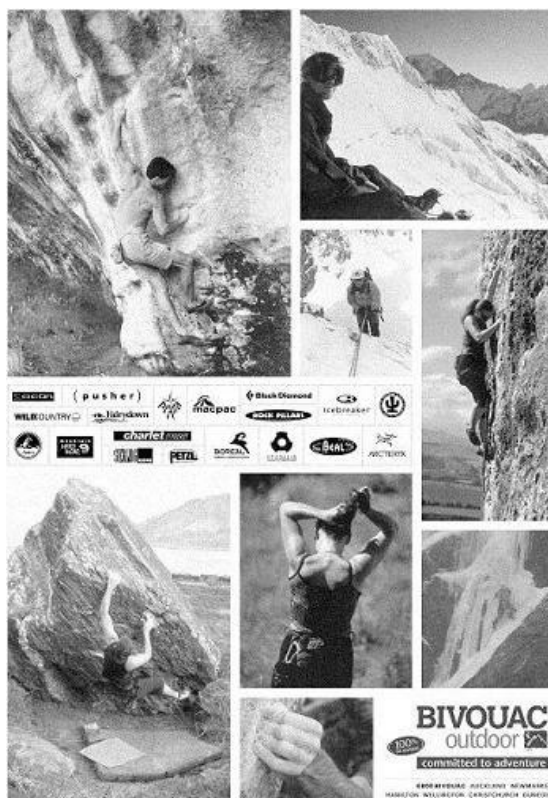


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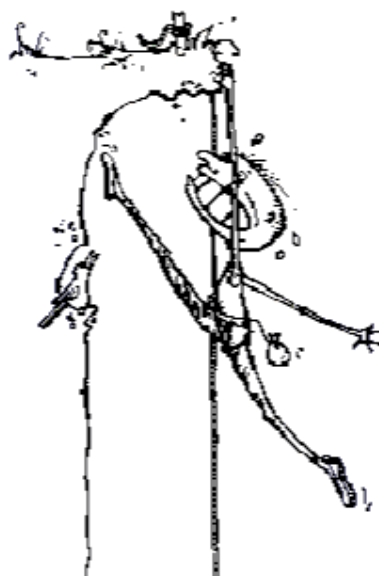




Wellington Section Directory: 2005 contact list

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Patron			
Chairperson	Nigel Roberts	CHAIRPERSON <i>or</i> NR	(04) 475 7543
Vice Chairperson			
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Treasurer	Caroline Duggan	TREASURER <i>or</i> CD	(04) 475 5542
National Representative	Caroline Duggan	CD	(04) 475 5542
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Instruction: RIC	Scott Taylor	SPRINGROCK	N/A
Trips	Michele Domaneschi	TRIPS <i>or</i> MD	N/A
	Rachel Depree	RD	N/A
Library	Derek Richardson	LIBRARY	N/A
	Peter Shanahan	PS2	(04) 934 7926
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	Rachel Depree	RD	N/A
	Michele Domaneschi	MD	N/A
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* Email address is alias@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz, eg: secretary@nzalpine.wellington.net.nz



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